

STATE OF TEXAS

COUNTY OF HIDALGO

Before me, the undersigned authority, on this day personally appeared Mr. H. L. Barber, known to me to be the person whose name is subscribed below and who, after being duly sworn, deposes and says as follows:

My name is H. L. Barber, and I am Superintendent of the Mission Public Schools, of Mission, Texas. I have been a Superintendent of Schools in Texas for fourteen years and, before that, I had four years experience in elementary, junior high, and senior high school principalships.

The practice of segregating the children of Mexican descent in the elementary grades was practiced in Mission when I first went there as superintendent more than ten years ago. Under my administration, the Mission public schools have ceased all semblance of this practice. At the present time, all children in Mission go to the school nearest their home, and all schools are operated on a common basis as regards efficiency, curricula, etc. This change in practice, from a policy of segregation to one of non-segregation, has been accompanied by a most encouraging improvement in the total educational situation for all children. My experience in bringing about this change prompts me to make the following observations:

There is no place in a democracy for discrimination against any group. The school that practices the policy of discrimination against a minority group definitely is encouraging a practice which in my opinion is contrary to the Constitution of the United States, and educating generations of peoples against the principles upon which our government was founded.

Relative to a segregation of the "Mexican" children in American schools, I should like to point out that the American, as we ordinarily refer to him, is a mixture of practically

all known nationalities. To the best of my knowledge the practice of discrimination against, or segregation of, the Italians, Greeks, Germans, Jews, French, or Japanese is not practiced in any section of our nation. Therefore, why should segregation be permitted to exist among our schools with large Latin American population? It is certainly more economical from a financial standpoint to maintain schools without segregation. Any school administrator will recognize the fact that it is more difficult to maintain the proper distribution from the teacher-pupil standpoint in segregated schools than it is wherein lines of nationality are disregarded. A school set up to serve the needs of all of its students definitely functions on a more economical basis inasmuch as the segregation calls for dual administration, unbalanced classes, extra teachers, and in many cases additional janitor service and more utilities. In many cases the segregated schools are operated almost as though they were in a separate district.

We believe, and practice, the policy of dividing our school district into its several smaller districts. The students who live within these districts (whose lines are determined because of the location of the school) attend the school in the district in which they reside regardless of national heritage. We find that, because of the extremely heavy elementary enrollment, it is necessary for us to maintain three schools of primary and elementary level. These schools go through the fifth grade. Beginning with the sixth grade our building facilities are adequate to take care of all children in the school district. One unit consists of the sixth, seventh, and eighth grades. The other unit consists of the ninth, tenth, eleventh, and twelfth grades. All students from every section of town attend these two schools. The students attending the lower elementary grades attend the school located in the district of their residence.

We have found in practicing this policy that our

attendance has increased at all levels. We find, further, that our children of Latin American descent, and as a matter of fact, that all people of Latin American descent, are becoming more conscious of the necessity for an education and the use of the English language.

We have been unable to determine any difference in the learning ability of the Latin and Anglo American children. We have further found that as many leaders in high school are developed among the Latin American students as among the Anglo American students, and that very little prejudice exists among either group. They are all accepted and recognized as Americans.

From an administrative standpoint, we are very emphatic in the fact that certainly the community after a reasonable length of time is much more solidly behind the schools if the policy of segregation is not practiced. The thinking people of any community are tolerant of all groups and are certainly intolerant of any practice which would tend to make conditions unequal for minority groups. Through policies such as we have pursued in Mission for the past several years an understanding can be reached among school patrons; and, beyond all question of a doubt, the English of the Latin American groups is improved, and I have been unable to observe that the learning has been retarded among our Anglo American children.

Further deponent sayeth not.

Affiant

Subscribed and sworn to before me this _____ day of _____,

1947. Given under my hand and seal of office.

Notary Public in and for Hidalgo Co.,
State of Texas. My commission
expires